



NEC VT700

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**digit**  
JULY 2008



Sony VPL-EX5

stream, so there's nothing much that's different here, although movie junkies would give HDMI a nod over DVI anyway.

It doesn't possess as good a contrast ratio as the VT800, although the colour and geometry was as good as its larger sibling. Text clarity is good, and so is the performance in presentations and animations, although it trails its sibling by a hairsbreadth. The same phenomenon occurs in the movie and gaming tests where the VT800 is slightly better. This is enough for us to recommend the VT800 over the VT700, especially, when you consider that the VT700 is actually Rs 3,000 costlier in India, that is, Rs 95,000. For all your needs, the VT800 is a much better choice as it's cheaper and performs better. However, the VT700 is an excellent projector in its own

right, but its pricing needs some adjustment.

#### Sony VPL-EX5

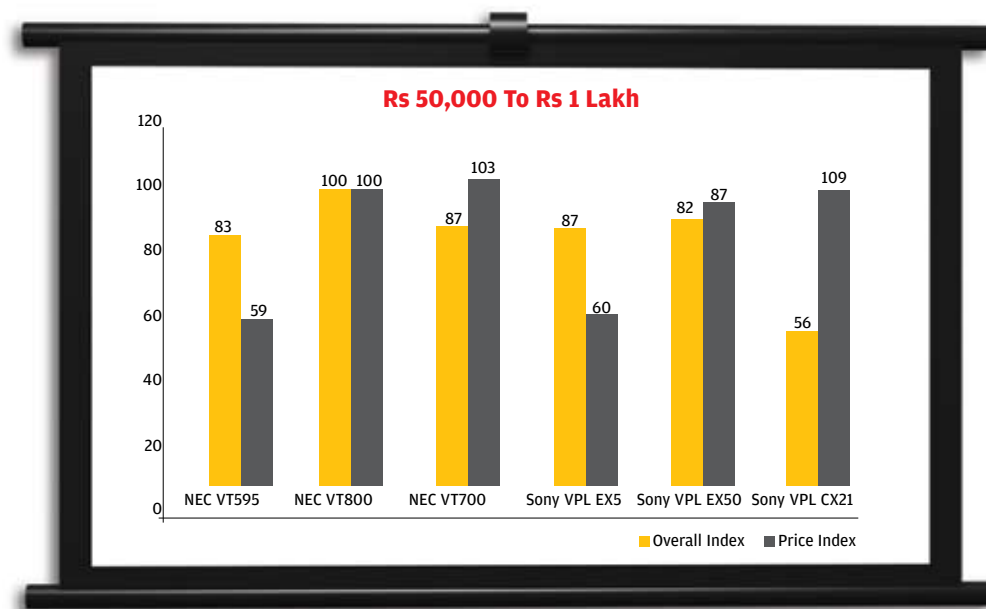
Sony's design department has come up with a winner as far as looks go. The VPL-EX5 is a beautiful looking projector finished in glossy white. The top body curves down the sides and this tapered shape looks refreshingly different. The remote control is small, and very slim. Aesthetics aside the buttons are the hard-to-press variety, and they're very tiny—all large-handed blokes beware! The zoom and focus adjustments are on the left side of the body and you might miss them (we did initially!) unless you look hard. Sony's menu is well laid out, and everything is easily accessible, although the options aren't as bountiful as the NEC projectors, where you can tinker around more.

This projector is no slouch when performance is the criteria. DisplayMate threw up some good results, very good contrast and colour, but we noted that the reds and greens seem a little too vivid—almost as if these hues are being heightened. This is also typical to Sony digital cameras (pardon the correlation) and we feel that Sony prefers rich, vibrant colours over tonal balance. Photos looked splendid when viewed on this projector—very good colour, and the detail was amazing. Not surprisingly, this is good for watching movies with great detail and crispness. It's a great projector to game on as well. *Crysis* and *FEAR* both looked amazing, and the HDR effects in *Crysis* in particular were beautiful.

Although behind the excellent NEC VT800 in performance, this projector costs a whopping Rs 37,010 less! When you're looking at 95 per cent the performance at 60 per cent the price, you just know you've found something special, and such excellent bang for buck is as rare an occurrence as spotting a dodo. A must buy! We know an amazing deal when we see one!

#### Sony VPL-EX50

Designed to look identical to the VPL-EX5, the VPL-EX50 adds an extra zero as a suffix to its sibling's name and a slightly brighter bulb (2,500 lumens opposed to 2,000 lumens). Once again, build quality is excellent, and the merits and demerits of the VPL-EX50 are also present.



Sony VPL-EX50

In terms of performance, the VPL-EX50 is a solid extension on its already excellent sibling. Whatever the VPL-EX5 does, this bad boy does a little better. Once again the issue with over-saturated, over-rich colours arises, but this can be toned down with a little calibration. Contrast is excellent and the VPL EX-50 performs very well, be it text, presentation or DisplayMate. Likewise, the movie performance was stellar, and while the difference between the two siblings isn't much, you'll notice it. In games, we were greeted with the kind of clarity that does justice to fast and expensive SLI or Crossfire multi-GPU systems.

For Rs 79,990, the VPL-EX50 isn't expensive for what it offers, unless you consider its cheaper sibling. If you want the best, then ditch this in favour of the NEC VT800, but you'll have to spend more. If you are OK with the performance of the VPL EX50, but want to spend less, then you should look at the Sony VPL EX5. Remember that the law of diminishing returns is firmly in place here—the extra five per cent of performance between the two siblings costs a whole lot more.

#### Sony VPL-CX21

The VPL-CX21 is a very compact projector with a fully metallic body. It's built extremely well unfortunately we received this projector without any remote control unit, and minus all the cables. Such exclusions are shocking from Sony. Nonetheless, connectivity options are pretty limited with only D-Sub and Composite as your options. A mini-USB connect acts as an audio / video connect and this is hidden away under a latch, in a small recess, which opens to reveal the menu buttons and a 4-way joystick. Using the menu is a pain, because all the controls are on the side of the projector and not very accessible. With your VGA cable plugged in, it's also difficult to reach the menu buttons.

In DisplayMate, we ran into some minor issues with contrast. Also noticeable were some issues with changes in hue in the *White Shift* and *Black Shift* tests, this shows a phase issue. There were issues with grey rendition, which we weren't able to fix with calibration.

In the text tests, we weren't convinced with quality, sharpness or clarity of alphabets and



Sony VPL-CX21

there seemed to be some haziness around the edges of fonts. The movie tests were kinder to this projector, and we couldn't find a lot to complain about, although, it's not as good as some of the other projectors in this test. Games were a mixed bag. While we couldn't find anything to complain about, we also couldn't find a lot to praise. *Crysis* was clear and with good lighting and colour, but it lacked a little extra sparkle that some of the other projectors were able to display, and clarity was also an issue. At Rs 99,990, the VPL-CX21 is pricey.

**Up To Rs 50,000**  
*For Modest Movie Buffs*

#### BenQ MP612c

The MP612c is a navy blue (alternating between matte and gloss) finished projector that is more planes and angles, than curves. Yet the design has something of a futuristic look that most of us



BenQ MP612c

found pleasing, if not desirable or even appealing. The remote unit is very small, compact, yet usable. One of the complaints we have with the connectivity is the inclusion of a single 3.5-mm jack to serve as an input, although considering that most users will have discrete speakers, but maybe we shouldn't complain. Note that all the NEC projectors have multiple 3.5-mm audio inputs, usually one for each video connect. DVI connectivity has been missed out on, as is the Component connect, a *de facto* for high-end video devices. A mini-USB connect has